

Public Companies: Retail Sector

Big box, specialty, off-price, and distressed retail across the major sub-categories

Context: Retail is sharply bifurcated in 2026. Value-oriented players (Costco, Walmart, TJX, Ross) and off-price are winning on trade-down behavior, while discretionary specialists and debt-heavy department stores face a historic bankruptcy wave -- commercial Chapter 11 filings were up 67% YoY by February 2026, the highest annual pace since 2010.

1. Big Box / Mass Merchandisers & Warehouse Clubs

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Walmart	WMT	World's largest omnichannel retailer, ~10,900 stores in 19 countries	FY2025 net sales up 5% to \$674.5B; net income up 25.3%; e-commerce, advertising (Walmart Connect), and Sam's Club membership scaling
Costco Wholesale	COST	Membership warehouse club; 90%+ renewal rate	Named a top 2026 pick by Bernstein; expected to benefit most from tax refund spending along with Walmart
Target	TGT	General merchandise big box retailer	Named alongside Costco as a key 2026 stock to watch by Bernstein; facing more discretionary-spending headwinds than Walmart/Costco
BJ's Wholesale Club	BJ	Northeast-concentrated warehouse club	Smaller-format warehouse club peer to Costco/Sam's Club

2. Home Improvement

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Home Depot	HD	Largest home improvement retailer; heavy push into pro/B2B via SRS Distribution	Completed \$5.5B acquisition of GMS Inc. (specialty building products) via SRS subsidiary; FY2026 guidance: comp sales flat to +2%
Lowe's	LOW	Second-largest home improvement retailer, expanding pro/B2B	Two consecutive quarters of positive comps, outpacing Home Depot; \$8.8B acquisition of Foundation Building Materials (Aug 2025); preferred over HD by Bernstein on valuation

3. Off-Price / Value Retail

The clearest 2026 winners: off-price benefits from a dual flywheel of excess vendor inventory and trade-down consumers.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
TJX Companies	TJX	Largest off-price retailer (Marshalls, HomeGoods, TJ Maxx)	Q1 FY2027 comp sales +6%, beat across every division; raised full-year comp guidance to 3-4%; also stands to gain share as Saks exits off-price
Ross Stores	ROST	Off-price apparel and home goods retailer	Surprised to the upside in Q1 2026 results alongside Ralph Lauren and Target
Burlington Stores	BURL	Off-price apparel and home retailer	Direct off-price peer to TJX/Ross benefiting from the same trade-down dynamics

4. Department Stores

The most distressed sub-sector -- see also the dedicated Distressed/Bankruptcy Watch section below.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Dillard's	DDS	Regional department store, healthiest balance sheet in the category	Closed just 1 store in FY2025; Q3 FY25 net income \$129.8M -- the standout department store avoiding the bankruptcy wave
Macy's	M	Largest traditional department store chain	Closing ~150 underperforming stores by end of 2026 as part of network optimization (14 closed across 12 states in Q1 2026 alone)
Kohl's	KSS	Mid-market department store chain	Flagged as high-risk on RapidRatings' 2026 bankruptcy watch list due to debt and outdated model concerns

5. Dollar Stores / Deep Discount

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Dollar General	DG	Largest US dollar store chain by store count	Cited among value-oriented recovery names in mid-2026 retail earnings roundups
Dollar Tree	DLTR	Dollar store chain (post-Family Dollar divestiture)	Refocused as a standalone Dollar Tree banner after divesting Family Dollar

6. Specialty Apparel

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Ralph Lauren	RL	Premium/luxury apparel retailer and brand	Surprised to the upside in Q1 2026; benefiting from resilient affluent-consumer spending on full-price product
Gap Inc.	GAP	Multi-brand apparel retailer (Gap, Old Navy, Banana Republic, Athleta)	Ongoing brand turnaround story amid a bifurcated discretionary spending environment
Abercrombie & Fitch	ANF	Specialty apparel (Abercrombie, Hollister)	One of the stronger specialty apparel turnaround stories heading into 2026
American Eagle Outfitters	AEO	Specialty apparel retailer	Mid-market apparel peer navigating the same discretionary bifurcation
Urban Outfitters	URBN	Multi-brand specialty apparel (Urban Outfitters, Anthropologie, Free People)	Multi-brand model has provided relative resilience versus single-brand specialty peers

7. Sporting Goods & Outdoor

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Dick's Sporting Goods	DKS	Largest US sporting goods retailer	Completed \$2.4B acquisition of Foot Locker (Sept 2025), adding ~2,400 stores and international footprint
Academy Sports + Outdoors	ASO	Regional sporting goods and outdoor retailer	Competes directly with Dick's in the value-oriented sporting goods segment

8. Consumer Electronics

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Best Buy	BBY	Largest specialty consumer electronics retailer	Reported continued weakness in appliance sales in mid-2026 earnings, flagged as a middle-income discretionary pressure point

9. Beauty, Pet & Home Furnishings Specialty

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Ulta Beauty	ULTA	Largest specialty beauty retailer	Core beauty specialty pure-play; benefits from beauty's relative resilience within discretionary spend
Chewy	CHWY	Online-first pet products and pharmacy retailer	Subscription/autoship model provides recurring-revenue characteristics within specialty retail
Williams-Sonoma	WSM	Premium home furnishings retailer (Williams-Sonoma, Pottery Barn, West Elm)	Benefiting from robust demand among affluent consumers for full-price product in mid-2026 results
RH (Restoration Hardware)	RH	Luxury home furnishings retailer	High-end furnishings peer to Williams-Sonoma, similarly exposed to affluent consumer resilience

10. Drug Store / Pharmacy Retail

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
CVS Health	CVS	Largest remaining public pharmacy chain, integrated with health services/insurance	Now the primary public pharmacy retail bellwether following Walgreens' take-private

Note: Walgreens was acquired by Sycamore Partners in August 2025 and is no longer publicly traded; it is closing ~1,200 underperforming stores and appears on multiple 2026 distress watch lists despite now being private.

11. Distressed / Bankruptcy Watch (2026)

Given how active this cycle has been, distressed names are broken out separately -- useful as a negative screen or a distressed-opportunity screen depending on your strategy.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Saks Global	Private (post-HBC)	Luxury department stores (Saks Fifth Avenue, Neiman Marcus, Bergdorf Goodman)	Filed Chapter 11 Jan 14, 2026 under \$2.7B merger debt load; emerged from bankruptcy court ~May 2026 with reduced debt and smaller footprint; exited off-price entirely (benefiting TJX/Nordstrom Rack)
QVC Group	QVCGA (pre-filing)	Home shopping/TV retail (QVC, HSN)	Filed Chapter 11 April 16, 2026 to restructure \$6.6B debt
Kohl's	KSS	Mid-market department store	Named on RapidRatings' 2026 high-risk watch list
Sportsman's Warehouse	SPWH	Outdoor specialty retailer	Shares fell 30% after cutting full-year guidance; Altman Z-Score of 1.57 places it in the distress zone

Leslie's	LESL	Pool supply specialty retailer	Cash fell to \$64M with worsening debt-to-equity; completed 1-for-20 reverse split in fall 2025 to maintain Nasdaq listing
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Categories Worth Adding

- **Online/E-commerce Pure-Plays** — Amazon (AMZN) and Etsy (ETSY) are the clearest public pure-plays, though Amazon's retail business is inseparable from its much larger cloud/AI business for screening purposes.
- **Grocery/Supermarket** — Kroger (KR) and Albertsons (ACI) were not included above; worth a dedicated pass given the FTC blocked their proposed merger and both remain independently public.
- **Auto Parts Retail** — AutoZone (AZO), O'Reilly Automotive (ORLY), Advance Auto Parts (AAP) form a distinct, historically resilient specialty retail sub-sector not covered above.
- **Retail Media Networks** — a cross-cutting theme (Walmart Connect, Target's Roundel, Kroger Precision Marketing) generating high-margin advertising revenue inside traditional retailers; increasingly analyzed as its own earnings driver rather than a separate company category.

Generated July 10, 2026. This is a disjoint reference set, not a ranked or filtered list.